P. Kumar. He claimed to have piles of evidence. But why then would he be driven to suicide, especially since his alleged tormentor was already dead? One line of speculation is that he feared arrest in the case.

Two dead police officers telling tales. Just diametrically opposite ones. Haryana, already struggling to contain the repercussions of the first case, was now reeling. If at all anything came through, it was the sense of a deep rift at the community level—colouring personnel dynamics within the police in violently antagonistic ways, then getting refracted back to society. Lather's agitated Jat village brethren were rushing a cremation, refusing a post-mortem. The politics looked like becoming too hot for any side to handle.

Kumar names his nemesis in his note: Haryana DGP Shatrujeet Singh Kapur, besides Rohtak SP Narendra Bijarniya and 14 others. It also mentions Rajesh Khullar, the CM's chief principal secretary, as an empathetic figure who understood his distress and tried to help. Minus the last, Lather inverts the plot. Regardless of their variance, what the two suicides lay bare is the rot at the heart of Indian policing. In its inner workings, it comes across as a machine moved mostly by mistrust and malign acts of obstruction.

On October 14, as pressure piled up on the Nayab Saini government, Kapur was sent on leave. Bijarniya had been already transferred, in a first bid to buy peace, but the ante was pitched too high for that to suffice. Kumar's wife, who was on a CM-led delegation to Japan at the time of the incident, was at the fore of the call for justice. A 31-member committee, largely comprising Dalit community members, lent it ballast. The Haryana IAS and IPS associations, too, backed the family.

Takeaways



- **Haryana police brass in a flutter as Dalit IPS officer Y. Puran Kumar dies by suicide**
- **Amid investigations and heated politics, a second suicide, this time by ASI Sandeep Lather (above), roils the landscape further**

'BECAUSE, DALIT'

The politics of caste at the centre of it all ensured the aftermath spilled beyond Haryana. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi was among the first to react to Kumar's suicide, accusing the BJP-RSS of fostering a "Manuvadi mindset" in institutions. The case is well aligned to the party's social justice narrative. Days earlier, Rahul had linked the Rae Bareli killing of Dalit youth Hariom Valmiki and the shoe attack on Chief Justice B.R. Gavai to what he called rising caste intolerance.

The BJP pushed back, accusing the Congress of using the tragedy to play "selective politics". Any sense of institutional bias, however, would mar its bid to build a support base among Dalits—especially in the Haryana-Punjab-Rajasthan-western UP belt where the community is in sizeable numbers and the Ambedkarite movement has deep roots.

A defensive stance was evident as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's October 17 rally at Sonipat was cancelled. The Saini regime crossed out its first-year anniversary celebrations too. But it's on the opaque upper echelons of police that the incidents shine a forensic torch. ■

▶ BIHAR

NITISH MARKS TURF, A FEW FEET LESS

Seat-sharing talks go chaotic on all sides, JD(U) takes lowest share ever

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

ANI



DIL MAANGE MORE Supporters of a disappointed BJP aspirant in Patna

ON THE MORNING OF OCTOBER 14, visitors to 1, Anne Marg—CM Nitish Kumar's official residence in Patna—would have met with an unusual sight. Gopal Mandal, Gopalpur MLA of the Janata Dal (United), was sitting outside on a dharna. The word was that his name had been dropped from the candidates' list. Bihar politics is used to poll-time dramas, but this was emblematic of something larger: the disquiet within the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA), where the ambitions of its five partners are going increasingly at cross-purposes. "The only difference between Mandal and the JD(U) is that the MLA can stage a protest; the party cannot," quips a party leader.

For the record, the very same day,